they are. After I was released from Bagram, I happened to meet some Indians. When they found I was there in Kandahar, I thought they would be grateful. But their behaviour was not proper'.[191] Finally, Muttawakil thinks that India's view of Afghanistan through a Pakistani-lens can do more harm than good to its ties with Afghanistan. He adds, 'one of India's biggest mistakes was to support the puppet Soviet regime in Kabul because the Mujahideen were based in Pakistan. India's second mistake was not to recognise the Taliban.'[192] With ruptures emerging within the Taliban and between the Taliban and the ISI, it is not unreasonable to believe that there was an authentic desire to engage with India during the 1990s. This does not mean all Taliban officials advocated good relations. There were competing advocacies within the Taliban on the India question, but interestingly, the dominant one was pro-engagement rather than anti-engagement. On the other hand, in India, anti-Taliban partisans dominated. A lack of communication between the two (due to geographical and material factors) led the partisans to feed upon the anti-India minority within the Taliban. Those Taliban that wanted to engage with India remained nonplussed by India's behaviour.

Sometime in 2000, the Taliban emissary to Pakistan, Mullah Abdul Saleem Zaeef paid a visit to India's then ambassador in Islamabad, Vijay K Nambiar—who had been in Kabul during the momentous events of April 1992 when Najibullah had tried to leave Kabul. While both had a cordial meeting, the whole exercise, according to Nambiar, lacked substance. 'I realised there was no way in which we [Taliban and India] are going to be truly connected with each other in any kind of an understanding', says Nambiar about the meeting.[193] Nambiar, a partisan, believed that the Taliban had been unable to swing itself out of the 'Pakistani circle of reasoning', making it difficult for India to seriously engage with them.[194] Even Hekmatyar, he says, could have been better than the Taliban in asserting his independence from Pakistan. In February 2001, senior Indian analyst Raja Mohan met with Zaeef during his visit to Islamabad. Coming after the IC-814 incident, and before the unraveling of the Taliban regime, Zaeef strongly urged India to change its approach towards the Taliban and not see the group as a proxy of Pakistan. Zaeef claimed that 'it is clear from our [Afghan] history that we are an independent people. We only follow the injunctions of Allah, our creator. We don't accept bondage to any other nation [read Pakistan]',